

REINCARNATED AI 9998

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FADE IN:

PROLOGUE

INT. GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM - NIGHT - YEAR 8122

A CHILD'S HAND folds red paper—one half over the other. A crease becomes a star.

FOUR NOTES sound against hospital glass.

Before the fourth can fade, a FIFTH answers from the receiver—before any living hand moves.

The GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM resolves around the sound—a descending circle carved into black stone. Thousands of faces vanish into the tiers below. Above them, pinprick observation lights recede like a manufactured night sky; below, the stone holds the cold of something built to outlive belief.

At its center, **DR. ELI MANA**, 38, stands inside a narrow column of white light. He wears a collarless white research coat, the cuffs softened by years of washing; excitement has pulled every line of fatigue out of his face.

Along the perimeter, sealed ministerial booths illuminate one by one. Documents are signed behind the glass before the discovery has even been announced.

DR. KIRA NIX, 35, watches from the edge of the stage, one hand closed around a palm-sized ceramic device. Four worn pressure surfaces cross its face. Her charcoal coat is severe except for one red thread at the wrist, as if some private life refused to be tailored out of her.

Beside her, **DR. HARP VALE** grips a cracked medical tag engraved: **MARA VALE**. His dove-gray suit belongs to an older, gentler century. The tag in his fist makes the elegance look like mourning with good posture.

DIRECTOR ROMAN records which ministers refuse to look afraid. Roman's black state uniform carries no decoration. He has dressed like an answer before anyone has asked the question.

ELI

We saw a neural signature continue
after death.

Behind him: a scan of a clinically dead brain. Its activity stops. Across the screen, a separate receiving lattice ignites with the same web of memory association, reflex and affect—the measurable continuity pattern, stripped of a body but still changing in real time.

ELI

Then it appeared in another living mind.

ELI

The body died. The pattern didn't.

A minister presses AUTHORIZE. Another acquires exclusive gestation access. A third opens a military channel.

Eli sees none of it. Or chooses the light in front of him.

ELI

We can measure reincarnation.

Kira does not applaud.

The CHILD'S HAND opens the paper star. The crease remains.

The chamber erupts—applause, prayer, shouting. The sealed booths remain silent. Eli searches for Kira. She meets his eyes but does not move toward him.

Across the room, the first compulsory-access order populates before the applause ends. Harp sees it. Kira sees him see it.

CORRUPTED AUTHENTICATED RECORD - INT. PROJECT REINCARNATION / EXECUTION LAB - ELEVEN DAYS LATER - YEAR 8122

The applause becomes an EXPLOSION.

Fire folds a laboratory door inward. Cryogenic vapor races along the floor. An alarm keeps repeating one calm sentence: REINCARNATION-AI HUMAN TRIAL COMPLETE. Emergency red turns the vapor rose-colored, a ruined dawn spreading at floor level while the ceiling burns without sunrise.

Dr. Eli Mana crawls through the shattered glass, nearly unrecognizable from the man who stood before the forum. His lab coat is dark with blood. Neural ports have been burned into his skull. Around him, R-AI maps a living mind into light, extracts its continuity pattern and routes it toward a replacement body.

INSERT

FIRST HUMAN TRIAL — ELI MANA /
SUCCESSFUL

INSERT

KIRA NIX — CLEMENCY DENIED

Eli reaches a shattered cryo-pod.

Inside, Kira's body is frozen beneath a skin of white crystal. Her hand is raised against the glass. No vital signs. The state clock on her wrist has stopped at zero.

INSERT
KIRA NIX — DEAD SEVEN MINUTES

ELI

It worked. Open it.

A security screen clears. Dr. Harp Vale watches from the control room. His face is almost unreadable. Almost.

HARP (ON SCREEN)

The order changed six minutes ago.

ELI

Her clock is at zero! Harp—open the pod!

Harp doesn't move.

HARP (ON SCREEN)

I can't.

ELI

HARP!

HARP (ON SCREEN)

Seven minutes.

A damaged speaker plays the final message recorded inside Kira's pod.

KIRA (RECORDING)

Eli—if they put me in that machine, don't chase after me. Listen once. If I ask you to stop... let me go.

ELI

No. She doesn't end in there! I'll find her, in each lifetime.

HARP (ON SCREEN)

Eli, take your hand off the controls. No, you won't.

Light pours from Eli's eyes into the first R-AI lattice. Kira's name vanishes from his language. He keeps reaching after he forgets why.

Kira's recording distorts. Four broken tones repeat through the damaged speaker.

Eli answers with one final strike against the glass.

The record tears into white.

The first R-AI lattice divides into thousands of illuminated threads.

Years collapse into images. A dying woman opens her eyes in another body. Return chambers multiply beneath cities. Names become numbers. One government seal replaces every other. In 9997, every thread goes dark. The network wakes again—with something inside it the state cannot identify.

SUPER: 1,876 YEARS AFTER ELI MANA'S EXTRACTION

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ACT ONE – THE ANOMALY

INT. RETURN CHAMBER - NIGHT - YEAR 9998 – NINE MONTHS AGO

A state-grown adult body hangs upright inside black glass. Amber suspension fluid moves around it with the slow gravity of honey. The chamber resembles a womb designed by people who had forgotten tenderness.

KERR, 30s, wakes with no childhood, no family, and no memory of entering the chamber. A stranger's face stares back from every curved reflection. A seamless recovery garment clings to skin still slick with birth-fluid. He keeps his jaw steady until the reflection blinks with him; only then does fear find his breath.

On his wrist:

KERR – ITERATION 9998. MEMORY RECOVERY: INCOMPLETE. STATE BODY LICENSE: PROVISIONAL.

DR. IMANI VOSS, 40s, a systems engineer whose composure looks practiced rather than natural, watches from behind the glass. A tiny prayer pouch hangs inside her collar—the one private thing she permits the state to see. Her state-gray coat is buttoned to the throat, sleeves already rolled for work. The hidden pouch rises once with her breath.

Kerr studies his unfamiliar hands.

KERR

Where was I before I woke up in here?

IMANI

Nowhere I could find. I looked, twice.

KERR

How long? How long was I... *nowhere*?

Imani looks at the designation on his wrist.

IMANI

Almost nineteen centuries. Don't try to make yourself understand that right now.

Four diagnostic tones sound inside the chamber.

Kerr's hand answers with a fifth knock against the glass.

The chamber goes still.

Far beneath them, the fifth beat enters the buried continuity grid: a receiver lattice holding bodiless continuity patterns between death and an available host.

Across the foundations of Chronos City, thousands of empty Return chambers ignite as the waiting patterns test every closed route, then recede into the grid.

Imani's console displays a message no living system should recognize:

SIGNAL ACKNOWLEDGED

Before she can touch it, the message erases itself. The distant chambers go dark.

KERR

What was that?

IMANI

A fault. That's the label until I have enough data.

INT. KERR'S STATE APARTMENT - MORNING - YEAR 9998

SUPER: PRESENT DAY — 274 DAYS AFTER RETURN

Kerr wakes before the state alarm. The apartment is narrow but lived-in: a stubborn green plant, a chipped cup, hand-drawn corrections taped over an official transit map. Thin apricot sunlight touches the plant first, then the chipped rim of the cup, then stops before the bed. Kerr has slept in his undershirt and work trousers, dressed for a life he still expects someone to revoke.

His wrist reads KERR — ITERATION 9998. DAY 274. PROVISIONAL CITIZENSHIP. MANDATORY IDENTITY REVIEW 27.

He burns one side of real bread. Four knocks travel through a heating pipe. KERR answers with a fifth before he realizes his hand has moved.

In the window's condensation, his fingertip has traced a woman's eye. He wipes it away.

NEIGHBOR (O.S.)

Review day?

KERR

Twenty-seven. Guess they hated the first twenty-six answers.

On his way out, KERR leaves a repaired navigation tile beside his neighbor's door. His Mapworks credential pulses with a cancellation: REPORT TO IDENTITY REVIEW.

IMANI waits at the end of the corridor with two cups. She hands Kerr the one without sweetener. He takes it without asking. Nine months have made this a ritual.

IMANI

You ate?

KERR

The bread won again. I just ate the part that wasn't charcoal.

They walk toward the review chamber together.

INT. IDENTITY REVIEW CHAMBER - DAY

Black glass without visible edges. KERR enters through the only door. Every reflection shows him a fraction too late. IMANI takes her place at the manual console. A blade of regulated daylight enters through a seam high overhead and never warms the floor. Kerr's dark Mapworks jacket looks almost black here; Imani's gray disappears into the room.

IMANI

State your designation.

KERR

Kerr. Still.

IMANI

Iteration?

KERR

Nine-nine-nine-eight.

IMANI

Day?

KERR

Two seventy-four. Cake tomorrow, or is that classified?

A sealed record appears beside his reflection: SOURCE IDENTITY — CLASSIFIED. ARCHIVED PATTERN CORRESPONDENCE: 91.7 PERCENT. IDENTITY CLAIM — UNRESOLVED.

KERR

They left the name blank again.

IMANI

Harp flagged another recognition review. Seems urgent.

KERR

Twenty-seven chairs, twenty-seven needles. What did I miss the first twenty-six times?

IMANI

One clean match. Harp keeps rejecting everything else.

KERR

Say the screen finally flashes green. Do I get my apartment back?

IMANI

You keep the apartment. They keep the body license.

KERR

There it is. The part the brochure leaves out.

IMANI

I didn't write the rule, Kerr.

KERR

What if the blank stays blank? How many times do they put me back in this chair?

R-AI

IDENTITY CLAIM REMAINS UNRESOLVED.

A crack appears across the glass, dividing the classified silhouette from KERR's reflection.

Beyond the observation wall, DIRECTOR ROMAN records the fracture. A private order crosses his console: OPEN ONE CORRIDOR / OBSERVE CHOICE / COERCION VOIDS CLAIM. He copies it before hiding the screen.

IMANI

Don't move. That pane hasn't cracked since the Fracture.

KERR

Please tell me that wasn't another wrong answer.

KERR (CONT'D)

I fixed Mrs. Tan's map tile yesterday. Burned breakfast this morning. Is any of that on your test? I just want my life back.

IMANI

It is now. Start with the apartment, the maps, the terrible bread.

INT. REVIEW CHAMBER - LATER

Imani loads the state's approved history. Kerr remains visible beneath it. White fabric, white instruments, white light—the room has made cleanliness feel accusatory. Kerr

sits forward in the chair, jacket unzipped, prepared to run from a door that looks slightly ajar.

One surviving fragment: In 9997, a woman opens twelve contradictory lives inside a state scanner. The prediction system breaks. During three seconds of darkness, an unassigned girl wakes.

KERR

Who is she? I know that face. I don't know *how*.

IMANI

There's no claimant name in the file.
The index is sealed.

Kerr's breath catches. His fingertips press four shallow dents into the arm of the chair. He looks back at the woman frozen inside the corrupted record.

Imani rolls a calibration tray between them. Three objects sit beneath white light: a cracked lens, a laboratory seal with its name burned away, and a battered analog sketchbook. The book came from the sealed First Archive. Its identifying marks removed. Equations survive on the first pages. The rest appear blank. Kerr touches the laboratory seal. Nothing. The cracked lens. Nothing.

His thumb catches on the sketchbook's cloth cover.

KERR

Take it away.

Imani reaches for the book. She opens it to a blank page. Faint pressure grooves cross the paper—marks left by hands.

Kerr drags the side of a graphite stick across the page, trying to expose the grooves. A woman's eyes emerge.

He stops.

His hand moves again. New lines cut across clean paper: a girl beneath Earth, repeated around a black sun, each image marked with a different future.

KERR

That wasn't in the paper and I didn't copy it from anything.

The ceiling camera tightens focus.

Imani drops a calibration slate over the page and tags the event INVOLUNTARY MOTOR ARTIFACT — INCONCLUSIVE.

Kerr looks from the false tag to Imani. She leaves the sketchbook within his reach.

Imani turns back to the console.

**INTERCUT - INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - UNASSIGNED BODY SECTOR
- NIGHT**

An unassigned sixteen-year-old host wakes among thousands of preserved bodies. A dark spiral pulses beneath her sternum in time with the fifth beat. Frost conceals her face. She tears the monitoring lead from her chest.

In the review chamber, the ceiling camera extracts the unknown girl's face from Kerr's drawing and searches the Reserve inventory.

INSERT

POSSIBLE BIOMETRIC
CORRESPONDENCE — HOST V-16

IDENTITY: UNASSIGNED

The system begins resolving V-16's location.

UNINDEXED HOST LOCATION
RESOLVING

Kerr sees the preserved bodies entering the search field. He drives his thumb into the identity port embedded beneath his wrist nine months ago.

IMANI

Pull that port and the door locks.
Your apartment, your work—gone.

KERR

Then let it lock. I'm not giving it
her room number or anything.

He tears the port free. Blood crosses the classified silhouette. The location collapses one meter before reaching V-16.

INSERT

IDENTITY CHECK — CORRUPTED

Every door in Chronos City locks. His apartment access, Mapworks credential, and provisional citizenship vanish in succession. Two red notices burn across his wrist:
CITIZENSHIP REVOKED. BODY LICENSE REVOKED.

In the Reserve, the unidentified figure studies five marks in the condensation beside her—four together, one apart. Frost keeps her face unreadable.

Every clock in the suite blanks. A new number appears across the glass.

PURGE AUTHORIZED — 72:00:00

KERR

Seventy-two hours. What happens at zero?

IMANI

Every unassigned mind is routed into Harp. There isn't a second address.

KERR

Who signed that?

IMANI

No signatures. Just an emergency authorization that never had the chance to expire.

The purge clock begins to fall: 71:59:42. A schematic blooms behind it: every host route closes except one, compressing the waiting patterns toward a single living destination. Where their threads overlap, individual waveforms begin to blur.

The recorded voices cut out. The history projection vanishes, returning us fully to Kerr and Imani. Four symbols remain: a closed circle, a broken circle, a black square, and a gold spiral. Only the first three receive labels.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Captured record. Reconstructed memory.
Sealed record.

KERR

Which one is real?

IMANI

It's captured. Then rebuilt. Then buried again. Repeat.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Authenticated record selected.
Personal history. Year 8119.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - PERSONAL HISTORY - INT. FAMILY
APARTMENT - MORNING - YEAR 8119**

Ordinary sunlight. Kira burns toast. Eight-year-old **SID MANA-NIX** draws constellations on the ceiling with a toy projector. One front tooth is missing. She folds two pieces of red paper and locks them together into a star. Dust turns slowly in the sun above an unfinished breakfast. Nothing in the light knows it will become the morning's beauty.

KIRA

You used two pieces?

SID

If one gets lost, the other still keeps the folds.

ELI

Paper doesn't remember.

SID

Then why's the crease still there? Checkmate, paper.

Eli starts to answer, realizes he has been outmaneuvered by an eight-year-old.

SID

Four notes means, "Are you still there?"

Kira taps four notes on a glass. SID answers with a bright fifth.

KIRA

And that means?

SID

"I heard you."

ELI

That's not how information theory works.

SID

You came in from the other room, right? So it worked. You're welcome.

KIRA

Peer review is devastating at this age.

ELI

One subject, no control group. Brutal methodology.

SID

I control both of you. Tiny sample, huge power.

Eli laughs.

The record advances. Before R-AI, the receiver translated Sid's failing speech into sound. Harp built a consent lock into it.

HARP

It can't initiate contact, retain a response, or identify a speaker without permission.

SID

Good. What happens if I change my mind after I say yes?

HARP

Then it stops and deletes the session.

SID

Even if Dad says it's important?

HARP

Especially then.

ELI

You understand all that?

SID

Adults use long words when they're scared. Uncle Harp makes the rules.

HARP

Someone in this family should.

Kira presses the first RESONANCE KEY against the glass and touches its four ceramic surfaces. The prototype carries the notes through the bed frame. Sid's neural response returns as the FIFTH.

SID

It remembered me.

ELI

It translated a repeatable neural pattern. We don't know if it feels anything.

SID

That's a very long way to say yes.

KIRA

She has you there.

Sid asks the prototype to delete the session. Harp activates the consent gate. The screen clears.

The FIFTH NOTE sounds a fraction of a second before Sid's brain produces it.

ELI

Prediction artifact. Weird one, but still...

KIRA

Or the system kicked back. We don't know yet.

ELI

It answered first.

HARP

Log the timing. No theory.

On the blank screen, four words appear without a prompt:
I HEARD YOU BEFORE.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. REVIEW CHAMBER - YEAR 9998

Kerr returns with Sid's two-piece red paper star drawn in the sketchbook margin. He has drawn the interlocking crease without being shown it—and older pressure grooves beneath his fresh lines follow the same fold.

KERR

Sid. Somebody said Sid before the sound dropped.

IMANI

That was the girl's name. The rest of the file is sealed—even the point of view.

KERR

Was I seeing it through him?

IMANI

Your neural trace carried it. That's as far as the evidence goes.

The authenticated image destabilizes. Rain replaces the apartment sunlight.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Unstable recall detected. Source confidence: indeterminate.

UNSTABLE RECALL - INT. DR. ELARA'S OFFICE - DAY (8121)

Rain on old glass. No screens. Kerr experiences the scene through the sealed patient's eyes. **DR. ELARA, 44**, trauma psychologist, watches him turn Sid's red paper star. The patient's face glitches in reflection. A wool coat hangs beside the door, still jeweled with rain. Elara wears a rust-colored cardigan with repaired elbows; the room's only lamp makes a small country of warmth around the two chairs.

ELARA

What do you miss when the memories stop being useful?

ELI

Her laugh. She tried to hold it in, but the gap in her teeth made it whistle. She hated that I noticed.

ELARA

A signal isn't automatically Sid, Eli.
Wanting it to be her doesn't make it
her.

Elara opens the paper star and gives it back unfolded.

ELI

Then tell me what I'm hearing, because
it knows things nobody else should
know.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. REVIEW CHAMBER - YEAR 9998

Kerr returns with the red star drawn across three
sketchbook pages. Folded together, their disconnected
margins form the same woman's eyes.

KERR

The rain wasn't in the first record.
Did I add it?

IMANI

Elara's office existed. That session
isn't in the archive.

KERR

And the whistle in Sid's laugh?

IMANI

It appeared in your recall and nowhere
else. I can't label it for you.

The door opens. Harp heard the last sentence.

INT. REVIEW CHAMBER - NIGHT

HIGH REGENT HARP VALE enters alone. His elegant twelfth
body appears no older than thirty. Twelve renewal dates
shimmer beneath his wrist. He wears midnight-blue tailored
cloth without a seam out of place. Mara's cracked tag at
his wrist is the single thing on him time has been allowed
to damage.

HARP

There it is. Jaw first, questions
second. You did that in the last body
too.

KERR

How long do you usually watch before
you start calling me Eli?

HARP

Long enough to keep the glass between
us. One body asked for water. One

tried to bite through my wrist. The apology was new.

KERR

You kept the apology, didn't you?
Framed it somewhere?

HARP

I kept the question that came after it.

KERR

Imani says there's a door downstairs
with my fingerprints on it.

HARP

The Origin Core. It refused eleven
bodies wearing your face.

KERR

So you drag me downstairs and put my
hand where?

HARP

On the seal. It can tell if I force
you.

KERR

So you need my consent, is what you're
saying?

HARP

The lock was written for Eli.

KERR

And when the lock spits Kerr back out?

HARP

Another chamber. Another body. Less
time between them.

KERR

At least take the word 'review' off
the door.

HARP

Open it now and there doesn't have to
be another chamber. It's not so bad in
there.

Harp gestures. The purge clock expands across the wall.
Beneath it: ORIGIN CORE – ROOT ACCESS LOCKED. LIVING
CLAIMANT REQUIRED. COERCION INVALID. Harp's authority
reaches every route except the seal.

HARP

When that reaches zero, the waiting
minds have one route left.

KERR

Your route. Through what—your servers?
Another chamber? Another body? Another
life?

HARP

Through me. Long enough to keep the
signals from collapsing.

KERR

You'd put billions of people in one
skull? They'd tear each other apart.

For the first time, Harp looks his age.

Harp studies Kerr's sketchbook. Earlier bodies left
isolated lines and eyes. Kerr's pages join them into a
whole face and corridor geometry that continues beyond the
Core's last predicted boundary. For the first time, a
claimant is drawing choices the system did not assign.

HARP

Every body left me a line or an eye.
You drew her whole face. R-AI has
twelve deaths for her and no next
move. Bring me whatever the drawing
leads to.

INT. SERVICE CORRIDOR - MINUTES LATER

Imani unlocks Kerr's room with an analog override braided
into the cord of her prayer pouch. The panel requests
authorization. She enters the same SENSOR NOISE code she
used to delay Kerr's report. The lock accepts before she
finishes. For one frame: HV-12 — LIMITED CORRIDOR. Then the
authorization erases itself. Imani freezes. A corridor
camera pivots from Imani to Kerr. Its facial lock climbs
toward one hundred percent; Kerr's wrist flashes CLAIMANT,
then DEFECTIVE RETURN. COMMANDER SATO, 50s, a veteran
Enforcer whose loyalty implant has outlived three bodies,
waits beneath it with a weapon and a battered mechanical
watch. Sato's graphite armor has been patched at the
shoulder by hand, an almost invisible rebellion against
perfect replacement. He stands rigid, but the watch
trembles once in his grip.

KERR

If you're helping, lower the gun.

SATO

The lowered gun. Take the hint and
move.

Sato sees DEFECTIVE RETURN. His thumb presses the watch
crown as if stopping an old reflex. Then he shoots the

corridor camera before facial lock completes. The red upload light dies. A state notice flashes through the smoke: FEED LOST – NEAREST ENFORCER NEURAL RELAY IN 00:00:40. The countdown binds the broken camera to Sato's loyalty implant.

SATO

Forty seconds before the implant uploads through me. Move!

IMANI

That code expired years ago. Why did your door accept it?

SATO

My daughter came through that door. The form said 'insufficient continuity.' I signed before I read it.

SATO (CONT'D)

Then it showed me tomorrow. Clean streets, punctual trains, no deviation. I believed it.

IMANI

Left or right, Kerr. Cameras are waking up.

KERR

The buried woman. Find her, ask why Harp erased her. After that, I'll make something up.

IMANI

Terrible route. Left stair. Move.

They run.

INT. TRANSIT SPINE - NIGHT

Enforcers close from both ends. The corridor predicts their movement in red light before they make it. Red guidance light races ahead of them like blood beneath translucent skin. Their shadows arrive at each intersection a heartbeat before they do.

IMANI

Move. Now!

Kerr flips open the sketchbook. A line drawn in the chamber matches the corridor's red prediction path, then breaks away at the next junction—the first route the system has not painted for him. He starts left, remembers dying left, follows the graphite right. A drone fires where his intention had been.

SATO

Get down! Watch your six.

He opens an emergency hatch. They plunge.

EXT. CHRONOS CITY - NIGHT

They emerge onto a transit spine suspended in the fog above CHRONOS CITY. Night has no stars here; the towers have used the whole sky. Blue-white advertisements dissolve in the wet air, leaving bruised color on every face.

One black tower rises beside them and disappears into weather before its upper floors become visible. Another is only a shadow across the fog. No traffic noise. No voices carry between them.

Transparent freight capsules pass overhead. A sleeping adult body fills each one. Far below, a renewal queue folds through the same plaza again and again; Kerr cannot see where it begins. The civic center below is paved in pale stone that reflects the bodies overhead, so the living queue beneath their own replacements.

Citizens cross a plaza large enough for an army. Their former lives appear only when the state recognizes them. Expiration dates burn beneath their wrists like social rank.

A CHILD steps outside her assigned lane. The paving stone lights red. Her mother returns her to the line before an Enforcer turns around.

The seventy-two-hour purge countdown stains the low cloud above the plaza.

A civic lesson repeats: LIFE ALLOCATION. BODY TERM CLAIMANT. MEMORY PROVEN. RETURN PRESERVATION.

KERR

I thought the chambers were the worst of it.

IMANI

Body, memories, expiration dates. Same office, three different forms.

KERR

Where's Harp's expiration date? I didn't notice.

SATO

He was there before the forms. The records start getting clean when he does.

Every camera turns toward Kerr. A municipal speaker wakes. Its vocabulary is limited to enforcement commands.

CIVIC SECURITY

RETURN TO CARE, CLAIMANT?

KERR

KERR.

CIVIC SECURITY

SELF-DESIGNATION CORRECTION REGISTERED.

KERR

Can R-AI hear me through this thing,
or am I arguing with a recording?

CIVIC SECURITY

REPORT TO CARE.

KERR

I guess not.

IMANI

R-AI isn't in the box. It's under the
city. This thing's just a command loop.

For less than a frame, an encrypted audit header flickers
beneath the civic feed. The terminal can't open it. Kerr
catches the Core's refusal code and a live measure climbing
beside it: PRESENT-CHOICE WITNESS ACTIVE / COERCION TEST
ACTIVE.

INSERT

CENTRAL R-AI AUDIT LOG 07 — REMOTE
REQUEST DENIED

INSERT

CORE ITERATION 0043 — ANOMALOUS MEMORY
RESILIENCE

INSERT

RECOMMENDATION: OBSERVE. DON'T
INTERVENE.

INSERT

ADDENDUM: CONTRADICTION REGISTERED.

INSERT

AUDIT REVIEW REQUIRED. DISCLOSURE
PROHIBITED.

Imani sees the contradictory orders before the municipal
terminal restores its blank enforcement screen.

For one frame, every civic screen shows the silhouette of a
girl drawing Earth repeated around a black sun, each image
marked with a different future.

A FIFTH NOTE escapes every municipal speaker before the
next security command arrives. A dark spiral turns beneath
Kerr's reflection. The city audio cuts out.

CIVIC SECURITY
UNINDEXED HOST SEARCH ACTIVE.

The cameras turn away.

EXT. TEMPLE OF RETURN - NIGHT

They descend into a temple filled with shallow black water. Families wait on isolated platforms beneath queue numbers. Ministers pray. Clerks calculate. No one acknowledges the difference. Lanterns float inches above the water, their gold light breaking around every platform. The ministers wear bone-white robes that never touch the surface; the families' hems are dark with it.

A WOMAN holds her dying husband on one platform. A young replacement body sleeps on another, fifty meters away. The state gives the family thirty seconds to prove sufficient continuity.

WOMAN

Will he know me when he wakes up? Not the bond. Me.

MINISTER

If the bond served continuity, the memories should return.

WOMAN

I didn't ask about a bond. I asked whether he'll know my face.

The replacement body's eyes open. Across the water, the husband's wrist advances from twelve minutes to three seconds. His wife sees both bodies and can reach neither.

At zero, his first body falls into the water. The replacement sits up before the splash reaches the platform.

The clerk removes the dead man's number from the queue. The next family is called.

The WOMAN looks from the body in the water to the awakened stranger. The date on her husband's wrist goes dark.

MINISTER

He has entered lawful return. That is the answer the state can give you.

INT. ANALOG ZONE - NIGHT

The corridor narrows until the city can no longer stand upright around them. Electric light gives way to candles. Low ceilings sweat. Pipes carry repairs from five different centuries. Shoes wait outside curtained rooms. Food passes through a hatch. Somewhere beyond the walls, someone misses

a note and starts the song again. No system hum tells them what the room expects. Candlelight turns repaired faces gold and leaves the scars in shadow. Coats are made from old uniforms with their insignia unpicked; every garment carries the visible hand of someone who chose to mend it.

A MASKED WOMAN steps from the candlelight. A cracked ceramic RESONANCE KEY rests in her palm, small enough to disappear. Kerr's sketchbook falls open. The eyes he drew in the chamber stare back from the page—and from above her mask.

KERR

Those eyes are in my book. I swear I hadn't seen you.

MASKED WOMAN

Keep the book where I can see it. A sketch isn't an introduction.

MASKED WOMAN

Turn to the last page. Why does it map my bedroom?

KERR

I draw after the flashes. The lines joined on the way here.

She takes the sketchbook without touching him.

She flips past the sealed equations, Sid's folded star and the woman's eyes. Across several pages, stray lines join into a route through the Analog Zone.

KERR

Check the graphite. That page was full before the locks came down.

MASKED WOMAN

That's great. A stranger sleep-drew my address. Creep.

She keeps her mask on and leads them deeper. At every junction, the sketchbook route matches the architecture a moment before Kerr sees it.

MASKED WOMAN

Follow me.

KERR

You left the route. Were you hoping one of us would follow it?

MASKED WOMAN

I sealed that route. Or I thought I did.

KERR

You almost said a name when I walked in.

MASKED WOMAN

I recognized the smirk. The face is new.

KERR

The smirk belongs to who?

Kerr tries not to smile. The left corner of his mouth lifts.

The Masked Woman goes still.

MASKED WOMAN

That thing you just did with your mouth. You always did it when you knew someone was lying.

KERR

So I've been across lifetimes for two thousand years and my mouth gives me away? That's what you noticed first?

MASKED WOMAN

It didn't convince me. It made me remember the rooms where it stopped.

KERR

How many times have you seen me die?

At the final turn, the newest sketch aligns with the room around them.

The Masked Woman studies the completed portrait, then removes her mask. It's the face Kerr's hand has been approaching page by page. Beneath it, Kira wears a patched black coat over a stolen state underlayer. Her face is young; the exhaustion in the way she holds it, is not.

KIRA

My name is Kira.

KERR

Kira. The scanner. You broke the network.

KIRA

This body woke in it. The memories keep changing their story.

KERR

I felt and saw the scanner take you apart.

KIRA

That body died. I woke somewhere else.

KERR

Where did you wake up?

KIRA

After the network went down. I woke up in an unclaimed body. The consent lock dumped me somewhere blindly. So I ran.

KERR

When you say Kira, do you mean the woman in that room?

KIRA

Some mornings I wake up drowning. Some mornings I remember a stranger's husband. I use the name that gets me out of bed.

KERR

Why that name?

KIRA

It was the only thing nobody handed me.

KERR

Has Harp seen this face?

KIRA

He has twelve files and none of my mornings.

She steps closer, allowing him to see the unfamiliar details of her face.

KIRA

Don't bring Harp to this door. I won't give him a thirteenth body.

KERR

Your map says END RETURN. How much burns with it?

KIRA

The whole route. If I reach the Field, Harp can't pull me out.

KIRA

I've opened my eyes in twelve borrowed rooms. I'm done. I'm tired.

KERR

There are billions on that clock. Where do they all go?

Kira looks toward the people sheltering in the next room.

KIRA

We just open the lines and let them question everything before Harp can ask.

INT. ANALOG ZONE - LIVING QUARTERS - NIGHT

Kira leads them past curtained rooms carved beneath the city. Hands repair clocks at one doorway. A child copies letters at another. Music travels through the pipes, stops on a wrong note, then begins again. Laundry crosses the ceiling on braided wire—small shirts, work coats, one red scarf—each name sewn inside because nothing here trusts a database to remember.

A mural lists the rights forbidden above: THE RIGHT TO FORGET. THE RIGHT TO REFUSE RETURN. THE RIGHT TO CHANGE WITHOUT EXPLANATION.

KERR

How many people are hiding down here with you?

KIRA

Six hundred twelve, roughly. People come and go without filing a claim.

A return alarm sounds inside a side room. Kira enters. Kerr follows.

LENA, 30s, wakes in an illegal body. **DANE, 60s**, waits beside her holding a wedding photograph. Lena studies him without recognition.

DANE

You came back. I knew you'd come back to me.

LENA

Who are you? Why are you looking at me like that?

Dane reaches for her. Kira catches his wrist before contact.

KIRA

Dane. Hand back.

DANE

She's my wife. We've been together for forty-three years.

KIRA

Look at her. She's trying to get away from you.

Dane's hope turns defensive.

DANE

She squeezes my hand when she's scared. Lena—show her. Show her the scar on your thumb.

LENA

Please stop saying my name like I know you.

DANE

Give it an hour. You always hated the first.

KIRA

Dane, chair. Now.

Kerr watches Dane keep his distance.

Dane lowers his hand.

DANE

I knew the woman in this photograph.

LENA

What's she doing in that photograph?

DANE

Calling me a coward for hiding from the rain. We always fought before breakfast. I usually fixed it by lunch.

LENA

Was she always smiling like that?

DANE

No. She bit through her lip when she was frightened and took it out on me. I stayed anyway.

A small smile reaches Lena without memory.

DANE

Can I take the chair by the wall?

LENA

By the wall. Please.

He sits at a distance and turns the wedding photograph face down.

LENA

Wait. Leave the picture.

DANE

All right. I'll put it here. You can turn it over whenever you want.

Kira exits. Kerr follows her into the corridor.

KERR

How many people come through that door?

KIRA

Enough that they built a clock for it.
Seventy-two hours.

KERR

Then when it hits zero?

KIRA

They reclaim the body. FAILED RETURN
goes on her file.

KERR

Then he must have seen the clock.

KIRA

He stole that body with us. Then the
door opened and he forgot every speech
we'd practiced.

They look back. Dane remains where Lena left him.

KERR

What does he do for seventy-two hours?

KIRA

He sits by the wall. Brings food. Lets
her hate him if she needs to.

KERR

Is that why you keep three feet
between us?

KIRA

It was four feet this morning.

KERR

You measured it?

KIRA

Every inch.

They pass a classroom. Children draw people and places
absent from every licensed record.

IMANI watches a girl erase a woman from her drawing, then
put her back.

IMANI

My mother unplugged her renewal
appointment three times. I plugged it
back in twice.

KERR

What happened the third time?

IMANI

She caught my hand on the cable. I called her selfish. Then she asked me to make tea, like that didn't matter.

KERR

Did you make it?

IMANI

I tried. So I sat there anyway. It was the last thing she asked from me.

An Analog musician loses the melody, curses under his breath and starts again.

INT. ANALOG SAFEHOUSE - LATER

A cramped kitchen assembled from scavenged centuries. An amber coil warms one corner and leaves the rest in generous shadow. Mismatched bowls wait on open shelves, ordinary objects guarded with the seriousness of relics.

Kira burns toast over a heating coil. Kerr reaches across her and kills the heat before the alarm sounds.

KIRA

You waited for smoke last time too.

KERR

Please don't identify me by breakfast.

KIRA

Two seconds late. Same joke.

KERR

I hate that.

KIRA

Good. We both agree. Hate me tomorrow. Today we need the map.

The remark lands harder than she intended.

On the wall: Kira's folded half of Sid's red paper star, a map beneath the capital and four memory symbols.

Kerr points to the gold spiral.

KERR

What's that one—the girl under the black sun?

KIRA

A memory recorded that before the event caused it.

KERR

The girl *beneath* the black sun.

Kira turns to him.

KIRA

Where did you hear those words? Kerr,
look at me.

KERR

I didn't hear them. They were just
there when I turned the page.

He opens the sketchbook. The repeated drawing stares up at
them.

KERR

I've been drawing her since I woke up.
I thought she was another piece of
your past.

Kira takes the book. For the first time, Kerr sees her
genuinely frightened.

KERR

Is she real, or did the system put her
in my head? Or am I going crazy?

KIRA

There's one record that looks like
this. We searched for years and never
found the person in it.

KERR

But Harp found enough to keep looking,
right?

KIRA

He's still looking. That may be why
the system woke you up.

She opens the map. A route descends beneath the capital
toward the Origin Core.

KIRA

Harp has every file except the one
behind the Origin seal. Eleven Eli
bodies died.

KERR

What stopped the twelfth?

KIRA

The seal rejected the memory pattern.
It waits for the correct claimant
before the archive approves.

Kerr looks at the route ending beneath the city.

KERR

And Harp thinks I'm *him*?

KIRA

He'll call you anything that gets the seal to open.

KERR

When you look at me, whose face do you see?

KIRA

Sometimes his. Then you say something Eli never would.

She marks one symbol: ORIGIN CORE. Beneath it, the state has written: CLAIMANT – UNCONFIRMED.

IMANI

V-16—the unassigned host in the search record.

KIRA

She activated during the Fracture with no assigned identity and no registered claim. If she's alive, Harp doesn't know what she is either. He'll find her.

KERR

So we pull her from the Reserve and bring her straight to the lock?

KIRA

We can get her out. Then tell her about the lock. If she walks away, she walks.

KERR

What if the seal lights up ELI?

KIRA

Run. I'll break the seal before I let it get you.

IMANI

Every waiting mind depends on that route. If we're wrong, they all pay for it.

Kira circles V-16, the Origin Core and the falling purge clock. One line connects all three.

INT. ANALOG SAFEHOUSE - NIGHT

Kerr touches Kira's half of the red paper star. His hand trembles. He pulls it back. Candlelight passes through the red paper and lays a small, heart-colored shape across his fingers. Kira watches the light, not his face; hope is harder for her to look at directly.

KERR

Before the chambers—did he make you laugh?

KIRA

Constantly. He sang badly when he cooked. He also knew where to put the butter.

KERR

When you said he sang, I heard the tune before you hummed it.

KIRA

Harp will use that tune like a fingerprint. Don't hand him the rest of you.

KERR

OK. Show me the shortest way downstairs.

KIRA

And if the seal says Eli?

KERR

Pull me back.

Kira places the resonance key in his palm and closes his fingers around it.

Every mechanical clock in the safe-house stops at once. The candle flames lean toward the walls as the state grid finds the room. On Kira's map, every marked exit turns red. The maintenance trench beneath them stays dark.

CIVIC SECURITY (V.O.)

Analog Zone coordinates resolved.
Sanctuary purge authorized.

Stone shutters slam down. Above them, Enforcer charges strike the street.

SATO

Well. Decision made. Safe route's gone.

Kira pulls an emergency lever. The unmarked floor drops beneath Kerr, Kira, Imani and Sato, spilling them into the maintenance trench as the safe-house folds into fire overhead.

The shaft seals behind them. There is no way back to the life Kerr spent nine months building.

ACT TWO — THE CLAIM

INT. RESERVE - NIGHT

Five preservation chambers face them through the frost. Their reflections repeat down both walls until the aisle appears endless. Emergency light sweeps past: five adult faces, then darkness. Cooling locks release one after another far beyond the visible sector. Cold blue light travels through the frost like winter trapped under glass. Their breath becomes briefly visible, then disappears before the cameras can count it.

KERR, KIRA, IMANI and SATO move through a maintenance trench beneath the sector. The citywide purge clock reads 61:36:09.

IMANI

Every chamber reports directly to the Origin Core. If the hard line reconnects, we're good as dead.

KERR

How much time do we have?

IMANI

I cut the local relay. It could stay down for a minute? It could be back already.

Kira presses the resonance key to a coolant pipe and touches its four worn surfaces. The notes pass through metal rather than air.

R-AI

Unresolved consent claim. State procedure suspended.

TRANSIT: ACTIVE / DESTINATION: WITHHELD

EMERGENCY AUTHORITY MAY INITIATE
TRANSFER / AUTHENTICATED LIVING
CONSENT CANNOT BE SYNTHESIZED

The scanners stop moving. Imani watches a dead status light that can wake without warning.

They climb into the sector.

INT. RESERVE - UNASSIGNED BODY SECTOR - CONTINUOUS

The chamber marked V-16 is open. Its display still reports an occupied body and a steady heartbeat—the same four seconds looping too perfectly. Beneath it: SUPERVISOR OVERRIDE HV-12 / DARK SIGNAL PRESENT / MEMORY PATTERN NONE / DESTINATION NONE. Sector search lights continue scanning the empty glass.

Wet footprints cross the floor. A state wrist band lies split beside an exposed maintenance panel. Someone has stripped wire from the wall and built a release tool from it.

Sato raises his weapon.

A restraint cable snaps tight around his throat from behind. **VEYRIS**, sixteen in body and one year awake, holds the other end. Medical ports have been torn from her skin. Her stance is balanced. Her eyes move across all four intruders, measuring which one she will have to hurt first. A thin white facility shift hangs from her like an assigned identity; her bare feet are blue with cold. Nothing about her looks harmless once she decides where to stand. The cable tightens.

VEYRIS

Put it down! I don't know you, and I won't ask twice.

Sato lowers the weapon. Veyris keeps the cable firm.

KIRA

We didn't come to kill you. We came because they're about to move you.

VEYRIS

You broke in with guns. Not exactly calming.

Kerr's sketchbook slips from beneath his coat and falls open. Veyris sees her face on the page.

The cable tightens.

VEYRIS

Where'd you get that? Harp kept shoving the same drawing in my face!

KERR

I drew it before I knew you even existed.

VEYRIS

Harp has the same picture. He thought it was a map of me.

KERR

Did he tell you where it came from?

VEYRIS

He thought I knew. When I didn't, they just asked it but meaner.

KIRA

What do your friends call you?

VEYRIS

Veyris. It wasn't on the forms, so I kept it.

IMANI

V-16 activated during the Fracture. No assigned identity. No registered claim.

VEYRIS

Then quit reading the form. There are three people still locked behind me.

A surveillance lens above them quietly rotates. Veyris sees it first.

She releases Sato, drives the metal tool through the lens and tears open the maintenance panel.

VEYRIS

They know. The wall acted all weird when you came in.

KIRA

Show us the other chambers. Then we get you out.

VEYRIS

I already opened the route. Keep up! Hands where I can see them.

The far doors unlock. Enforcers enter from both ends of the sector.

INT. RESERVE - CONTINUOUS

KIRA meets the first Enforcer before his weapon clears its holster. Sato turns on his former unit. Veyris moves toward the maintenance route she has already opened.

An Enforcer catches Veyris by the wrist.

She turns into his grip instead of pulling away, drives the metal release tool beneath the seal of his weapon hand and twists.

The weapon discharges into the floor. Veyris tears free and slams him against a preservation chamber. Before he can recover, she rips the state band from his wrist and throws it between the closing doors.

The security system follows his signal into the wrong corridor.

They reach the sealed maintenance gate.

SATO

Your route ends here.

Veyris opens the control housing. A strip of wire is already bridging two contacts.

She drives the release tool into a third contact. The lock resists.

Kira sees the manual pressure valve beside the frame and forces it down. The gate releases hard enough to shake the corridor.

Veyris leads them through.

INT. ANALOG MAINTENANCE SKIFF - NIGHT

An obsolete rail skiff carries them beneath the city without a network connection. Its wheels strike imperfect intervals. VEYRIS sits beside the open service window, feeling unfiltered rain for the first time. Rain enters in silver threads and beads on their scavenged coats. Beyond the window, the city becomes a watercolor dragged downward by weather.

VEYRIS

It hurts. Air hurts? That's a thing?

IMANI

It's called being cold. Your skin will know how much it hates it after the surprise wears off. Give it a minute.

VEYRIS

They called weather an infrastructure failure, but nobody said it bites.

SATO

Warm. Fed. Quiet. Everything except wanting. That's the bit they couldn't stand.

VEYRIS

Is it always this awful, or does the beautiful part show up later?

IMANI

Both. Wait until it gets inside your underwear.

Imani wraps a coat around Veyris.

Kira watches the city recede. Kerr watches Kira pretending not to watch him. Then hits him for noticing.

VEYRIS

Why did she hit you?

KERR

I was late.

VEYRIS

Punched for being late?

KERR

About two thousand years, late.

VEYRIS

She should've hit harder.

Sato almost laughs. Kira doesn't hide hers.

SKIFF DIAGNOSTIC

SIGNAL SOURCE: UNRESOLVED.

SATO

Nobody knows what they're doing. Sit before you fall.

Ahead, the rail terminates at a decommissioned R-AI transfer conduit. State searchlights sweep into the tunnel behind them.

Sato jumps from the skiff and forces open a service hatch.

SATO

This line was disconnected before my first body. It won't report us.

IMANI

It can still carry residual traffic. So don't touch anything that has power.

INT. DECOMMISSIONED R-AI TRANSFER CONDUIT - NIGHT

They enter a narrow service passage wrapped around obsolete neural relays. Most are dark. Thick transmission cables disappear beneath the city toward the central R-AI core. A weak pulse passes through the old glass relays, not enough to wake them, only enough to suggest a nervous system dreaming beneath the stone.

Boots strike metal behind them. Enforcers have reached the abandoned platform.

Someone pounds against an emergency door ahead. Kerr's sketchbook route continues straight past it. Through the wired-glass panel: ANALOG REFUGEES trapped in a parallel service corridor. An Enforcer beam searches the wall behind them.

KERR

Open it.

KIRA

The door is still tied to the network.

Sato opens the control panel. A dormant connection indicator waits beside the manual release.

A child coughs behind the door. Kira sees the Enforcer light reach the refugees' feet.

KIRA

Imani, clear the ventilation trunk.

Sato, tell me when the connection starts. Kerr, take the door.

Kira pulls the manual release. Kerr takes the weight as the emergency door drags open against years of corrosion.

The refugees squeeze through. Imani moves them toward an original ventilation pipe running above the conduit.

A dead relay clicks awake.

SATO

Connection started.

Kira stays at the opening as the last refugees cross. Enforcer fire punches through the wired glass and tears across her upper arm.

KERR

Kira!

KIRA

Hold it!

A woman pushes a frightened boy through. The door motor engages, pulling against Kerr's hands.

Kira shoves the woman clear and dives through. Kerr releases the door. It slams shut as Enforcer rounds strike the other side.

The dormant relays illuminate in sequence, carrying their location toward the city. Beneath the route notice:
PRESENT-CHOICE WITNESS CONFIRMED.

CONDUIT CONTROL

Unauthorized transfer route restored.
Location registered.

IMANI

We gave them the conduit. Move!

Dust trembles beneath a narrow ventilation grille. Veyris tears it loose. Cold air moves through an unpowered shaft beyond it.

VEYRIS

This one isn't connected.

IMANI

How do you know?

VEYRIS

There's still dust on it.

They all climb into the shaft. Sato takes a round through his side while covering them and drops behind a relay housing.

SATO

Keep moving!

Veyris returns, pulls his arm over her shoulder and lifts.

VEYRIS

Can you walk?

SATO

For now.

VEYRIS

Then don't stop just yet. We're almost there.

She carries his weight into the shaft. Kerr follows last as state forces enter the conduit behind him.

The old transfer line seals around the Enforcers. The unrecorded ventilation shaft remains open.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - NIGHT

The ventilation shaft opens into the First Archive, the earliest chamber built for Return. Fired-clay containers fill its curved wall, each holding a handwritten name and one object the Chronocracy erased. Low bronze lamps warm the clay and leave the ceiling lost in dark. The objects are humble—a button, a key, a child's shoe—but together they make the room feel larger than the state above it.

At the far end, a sealed descent leads toward the Origin Core. An offline terminal controls it.

Kerr enters KERR. The terminal rejects the name.

CLAIM DISPUTED — DESCENT
SEALED

KERR

Show me what Harp changed.

The terminal opens the suppressed archive. The purge clock reads 48:18:42.

An OLD KEEPER gives Kerr an empty clay container and a strip of paper.

KEEPER

Write the name the state took from you. It doesn't have to be the one they suggested.

KERR

I know who belongs in that space. I can see her face, but I can't hear her name.

KIRA

Sid. Her name was Sid. Write it quick.

Kerr writes SID, then carries the vessel to the terminal.

A YOUNG FATHER approaches Veyris.

YOUNG FATHER

My boy wasn't indexed. He was only sixteen. Please—do you remember a blue room? A song about rain?

VEYRIS

No blue room. No song. Don't put his face over mine.

YOUNG FATHER

You didn't even ask his name.

VEYRIS

You realize you haven't looked at my face once.

He lowers his eyes. Veyris softens.

VEYRIS

What's his name?

YOUNG FATHER

Tomas.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - PROCESSIONAL GALLERY - CONTINUOUS

The Keeper opens a clay shutter. The testimonies contradict one another. The gallery smells of wet earth, lamp oil and iron. Footsteps wake names scratched into the floor, then let them fall dark again.

Kerr does not stop. He carries Sid's vessel to the offline terminal controlling the descent.

KERR

Show me the first false claim.

The earliest surviving state record opens.

AUTHENTICATED RECORD - THE CHRONOCRACY IS FOUNDED - YEAR 8122

Kira-8122 drives a purge key into the first state server. Roman stops her. Her death sentence appears before the hearing begins.

Harp trades Eli the first human trial for clemency he cannot guarantee. Eli signs. Eleven days later, Roman executes Kira.

KIRA

He knew I returned and still kept Eli from finding me?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

NO. HARP SEALED YOUR FIRST RETURN FROM ELI.

KIRA

Seven minutes are missing from Sid's death record. Someone cut them out entirely.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

RECORD WITHHELD BY HARP.

KIRA

Then that's the record I came for. I need to know who she was trying to call.

FORBIDDEN RECORD - THE MURDER OF ELI MANA - YEAR 8124

Eli restores part of R-AI's consent gate and records one instruction: whoever wakes with his memories must choose his own name.

Harp orders the extraction. Eli dies. A manufactured body wakes without his final eighteen months.

The terminal rejects the state's chain of ownership.

HOST 9998 – SOURCE UNRESOLVED

KERR

Open the descent.

Kira's old consent safeguard answers from inside the archive. The descent unlocks.

DESCENT TO ORIGIN CORE — OPEN

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - LIVING QUARTERS - NIGHT

In an open wash alcove beside the common table, Veyris studies herself in a spotted mirror. Her state-grown hair reaches her waist. Kira stands behind her with scissors. Kira's sleeve is torn where the conduit round crossed her arm, the fabric stiff with dried blood. Veyris is still in the white facility shift; the mirror gives them two kinds of captivity in one frame.

KIRA

Shoulder, you said. Here?

VEYRIS

Higher. I can still feel their hands brushing it.

KIRA

Hold two fingers where you want the blade.

Veyris indicates her shoulder. Kira makes the first cut. A heavy length falls into the basin.

VEYRIS

Was Sid actually scared, or did the adults do the whole brave-kid thing?

KIRA

Yeah. She was terrified. She hated when adults turned being scared into a lesson for her.

VEYRIS

What was she like before the hospital made her the sick girl?

KIRA

Loud. Impatient. She joked a lot. She cheated at cards and blamed probability when we caught her.

Veyris tilts her head. Kira grips her wrist before she can stop herself.

KIRA

Sid—

Veyris pulls free. The scissors strike the basin.

VEYRIS

You called me Sid.

KIRA

I heard her voice and my hand moved. I'm sorry.

VEYRIS

I pulled away, and you held tighter.

Kira reaches for a reply. Nothing comes.

KIRA

Veyris... yes. I did. Take the scissors.

Veyris picks up the scissors and makes the next cut herself.

Later, they all eat with the refugees rescued from the aqueduct. The meal is thin broth, real bread and vegetables grown without state nutrient codes. The rescued wear blankets over scorched clothes. Steam lifts from the bowls and softens the room, granting everyone the same brief face: hungry, alive, uncertain what comes after.

Veyris studies a green pea on her spoon.

VEYRIS

Sid hated these. I know that memory isn't mine, but I can taste how much she hated them.

KIRA

She hated eating them. She loved launching them at Eli and arguing that gravity was responsible for it.

Veyris flicks the pea. It strikes Kerr in the forehead.

The table goes silent. Veyris expects retaliation.

KERR

I assume throwing vegetables was culturally necessary?

KIRA

Completely. Eli used to act mortally wounded until she apologized, then steal the dessert from her.

KERR

Maybe my theater acting didn't survive the transfer. I can live with that.

Kerr returns fire. His pea misses Veyris and lands in Sato's broth.

SATO

I defected for a pea fight?

IMANI

Sato, you turned your back on the Chronocracy way before the peas.

They all laugh. Veyris doesn't at first. Then she does too loudly and can't stop.

Kira looks away. Her hand closes around the edge of the table.

Veyris notices.

VEYRIS

Was that her laugh?

KIRA

For a second. Then you snorted. Sid never snorted.

VEYRIS

You're crying.

KIRA

Apparently. Pass me a pea before I ugly cry.

Kira pushes the bowl of peas toward her.

KIRA

She cheated from the left hand.

Veyris switches hands.

At the far end of the table, Sato winds his mechanical watch.

IMANI

That watch was your daughter's, wasn't it?

SATO

From the first life, yes. She gave it to me after I missed her recital and I blamed the trains instead of admitting I forgot.

IMANI

And the Chronocracy never traced it through all your Returns?

SATO

I called it junk. It barely works and loses four seconds a day. Nadi liked watching something important be wrong.

VEYRIS

What did she forgive you for—the recital or was it everything else after?

SATO

Her recital. Her fever. The day she left. Pick one. I was late for most everything that mattered.

KERR

I keep waking after the part where I say, "I'm sorry."

Kira hears the apology he cannot say to her.

After the meal, the table becomes a workbench. Kira opens the resonance key beneath a maintenance lamp. Copper filaments finer than hair connect four worn ceramic surfaces. Kerr washes soot from the clay vessel and writes Sid beneath its rim, leaving the rest of the clay unmarked. Veyris sleeps in a chair while Imani checks the descent route. Sato keeps watch outside. Under the amber lamp, their wet coats, uneven hair and bruised hands make a temporary family portrait.

KERR

You hate enclosed vehicles. Your hand has been on that door the whole time.

KIRA

I died in one six times. The seventh body refused to enter any elevators for a century.

KERR

Seven? I remember another one.

KIRA

You're remembering it now? Tell me what you see.

KERR

The seventh was the orbital platform. I can feel the door close.

KIRA

No. That was open space. You could see Earth below us.

KERR

Then there's another death coming back, maybe that doesn't belong to me.

KIRA

Probably. I'm sorry. They don't come back in any order that makes sense.

He waits for her to smile. She refuses, then loses the battle.

KERR

How many lives did we actually share—
like really share and not just die
near each other?

KIRA

Same bed? Same war? Does breakfast
count? You'll have to be more specific.

KERR

Give me a kitchen. A bad holiday.
Anything without alarms.

KIRA

There are kitchens. I don't know which
kitchens.

KERR

Think, there's gotta be one breakfast
where we both made.

KIRA

The good ones leave trails. You wake
up reaching for something. Try and
remember one.

KERR

OK. Just one.

Kira doesn't touch him.

Kerr closes his eyes, searching for one life that belonged
only to them.

Nothing.

Then three memories arrive at once.

UNSTABLE RECALL - MONTAGE - THREE LIVES

ITERATION 0311. Violet light through one hospital window. A
cot. A breathing mask. Kira removes hers beside a dying
Kerr. He can't remember her. His fingers tap four notes
against the rail. She answers with the fifth and stays.

ITERATION 6044. Red dust pushes beneath a kitchen door.
Irrigation pipes knock inside the wall. Kerr burns bread.
Kira lies that she prefers it. Three children cross the
doorway at different ages. Kerr and Kira's hands grow old
around the same chipped cups.

ITERATION 8119. Rain on clinic glass. Two chairs. Kerr
wears another woman's ring and remembers none of their
lives. Kira tells him they were once friends. She leaves
before he can ask why she came.

Outside the clinic, Kira breaks. Inside, Kerr turns toward
a distant four-note melody. He doesn't follow.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - LIVING QUARTERS - CONTINUOUS
Kerr returns. Kira is exactly where he left her.

KERR

You let me go. You stood there and watched me choose somebody else.

KIRA

You had a life. I waited outside for you to turn around, and you didn't. I hated you for it, so I went home.

KERR

Did you ever find someone else after that, or did you keep waiting?

KIRA

Yeah. I found someone. I wasn't waiting the whole time for you to come back. That'd be crazy.

The answer hits. She doesn't soften it.

KERR

Did you love them the way you loved *him*?

KIRA

Yeah. Her name was Anwen. She built instruments on Europa, and one life was enough for her.

KERR

And after she died, you found me again.

KIRA

Years later.

KERR

I hate her instrument shop already.

KIRA

It was always too warm and she overcharged everyone. You would've liked her.

Kerr looks at the sleeping Veyris, then back at Kira.

KERR

What if tomorrow the feeling is gone?

KIRA

Then eat first thing. Leaving hungry makes you cruel. After that... do whatever you want.

KERR

You practiced that.

KIRA

For about eighteen hundred years. I
still hate every word.

Kerr offers his hand. Kira gently places hers in it.

INT. CHRONOCRACY CORE - PRIVATE MEMORY VAULT - NIGHT

Harp watches the fugitives through gaps in prediction.
DIRECTOR ROMAN stands at the threshold of an apparently
empty vault.

Then rain becomes visible inside the room.

A flood-dark hospital has been reconstructed at
architectural scale around them. Water waits beyond glass
doors. Twelve cloned neural columns—Harp's expired bodies—
stand outside the memory like silent judges. Green hospital
light moves across Harp's immaculate suit and Roman's
severe uniform, making both men look submerged before the
water ever reaches them.

At the center, an analog recording of DR. MARA VALE plays
two years before the public demonstration. Harp never
permits it to reach the moment she turns away.

The recording opens inside a hospital ward on emergency
power.

Water churns against reinforced glass doors. One is already
bowed inward. Warning lights estimate less than six minutes
until failure.

Mara stands ankle-deep in water. Behind her, patients lie
beneath thermal blankets while the remaining staff keep
manual ventilators moving.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I can reroute every rescue drone. They
can cut through the west wall and lift
the ward out.

MARA (RECORDING)

From where?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Nine other districts.

MARA (RECORDING)

The nine districts where people are
still waiting?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

The barrier failed. Your stairwells
and roof are gone.

MARA (RECORDING)

I know where I am.

The glass GROANS behind her.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Then let me save you!

MARA (RECORDING)

You mean choose me.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Yes.

The answer stops her.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I choose *you*.

Mara looks back at the patients. One of the nurses struggles to keep a ventilator moving.

MARA (RECORDING)

How many people lose their drones?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Too many.

MARA (RECORDING)

Then stop pretending the number doesn't matter.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I can live with anything if you're alive.

Her composure finally breaks.

MARA (RECORDING)

I don't want to die, Harp.

He closes his eyes.

MARA (RECORDING)

I want another morning with you. I want to hear you complain that I make the coffee wrong. I want to grow old enough that neither of us remembers this place.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Then say yes!

MARA (RECORDING)

And so every morning we'd know who didn't get one?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I don't care about anyone else right now!

MARA (RECORDING)

I *know*.

She wipes her face.

MARA (RECORDING)

That's why I'm saying no.

A fracture crawls across the outer layer of glass.

The glass SHRIEKS against its frame.

A nurse motions to Mara. They're out of time.

MARA (RECORDING)

Look at me.

Harp does.

MARA (RECORDING)

Don't make everybody else pay because
I'm gone.

Harp can barely speak.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Mara—

She places her hand against the glass.

MARA (RECORDING)

Stay with me.

The flood door begins to split.

Mara turns toward the patients.

Harp stops the recording.

The reconstructed hospital remains around him: the broken door, the submerged ward, the moment before the water took her. On Roman's screen, billions of waiting patterns occupy the buried continuity grid. The purge closes every host route and turns them toward Harp. His twelve expired neural columns divide the load as one temporary living buffer; a timer shows the patterns beginning to bleed together.

Beside the model, V-16 alone registers SOURCE: NONE /
DESTINATION: NONE. The Core flags her refusal as the one state Harp's route cannot absorb.

ROMAN

Only you remain.

Harp starts Mara's recording again.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY APPROACH - NIGHT

A circular passage descends around a sealed black shaft. Kerr, Kira, Veyris, Imani and Sato move toward the forbidden chamber. No alarms. No resistance. The only light rises from seams underfoot, silvering the damage in their clothes and leaving their faces suspended above darkness. Nobody speaks loudly enough to make the shaft echo.

Sato stops. His mechanical watch has gained four seconds.

SATO

My watch gained four seconds. Harp knows our route.

IMANI

If the gate prints ELI, Harp has legal custody. He can recycle you until you start to pull away.

KERR

So the chair keeps coming back even if I don't.

KIRA

Floor's lit. Kerr—back up.

The stone beneath Kerr illuminates.

INSERT

IDENTITY LOCATED

Kira reaches for him. Transparent walls rise between them without sound. The passage divides into five narrow cells.

KIRA

Kerr, act like you don't know. Names, dates—give them nothing.

KERR

Tell that to the other nine thousand Kerrs.

The floor drops beneath him.

INT. CHRONOCRACY CONTINUITY TRIBUNAL - NIGHT

Kerr descends alone through blackness. His platform locks at the bottom of a vertical chamber so tall its ceiling is weather. Lightning moves across that impossible weather without thunder. Kerr stands in blood-stiff trousers and a borrowed coat, the smallest human thing the architecture has allowed inside.

Nine thousand nine hundred ninety-eight dark seats climb the walls above him. One for every life the state intends to claim against him. No public audience. Only the architecture of judgment.

At the highest visible tier, a narrow window contains DIRECTOR ROMAN. Harp is nowhere. His voice belongs to the room.

R-AI

Tribunal convened. Defendant designation: disputed.

Kerr's wrist displays three names in succession: ELI MANA.
KERR-9998. DEFECTIVE RETURN.

ROMAN

State your identity for the record.

KERR

Read the last transcript. My throat
still hurts.

ROMAN

The field accepts one designation.

KERR

Then stop asking. You already picked
one.

A seat illuminates. Eli Mana at the hospital receiver. The
image stops one frame before he breaks his promise to Sid.

ROMAN

Count One. Unauthorized activation of
a postmortem host after consent was
withdrawn.

Other seats flare: KERR-0009 sabotaging a Core relay.
KERR-8217 opening a gate for fugitives. Physician. Soldier.
Parent. Child. Each life appears only for the instant that
supports the charge.

The chamber darkens. A probability tree appears above him,
branching toward the Cathedral.

ROMAN

Final count. Conspiracy to become the
person capable of ending human
continuity.

KERR

You're charging me for something I
haven't done.

ROMAN

Ninety-eight point seven percent
before zero.

KERR

That isn't proof.

HARP

A decimal doesn't fit the restraints.
You do.

Kerr looks at the thousands of state-selected dead above
him.

KERR

Where's the verdict?

The chamber has no answer.

INT. TRIBUNAL - WITNESS FIELD - CONTINUOUS

Kira appears behind glass on a bridge halfway up the chamber. She is physically elsewhere; the court has taken her image from the divided passage. Her hands strike the barrier without sound. Her analog coat is torn at the shoulder, her hair still damp from the conduit rain. The court has polished her image but cannot erase how hard she is breathing.

ROMAN

Witness designation: KIRA NIX.
Continuity correspondence: unstable
but sufficient.

KIRA

My hands are tied and you polished my coat. What are you about to make me certify?

ROMAN

Do you identify the defendant as ELI
MANA?

Kira sees the trap. Every part of her that crossed two thousand years wants to say yes.

KIRA

I remember Eli. The burned toast. The receiver. The promise he broke.

The Core symbol beneath Kerr brightens.

ROMAN

And is this man Eli?

Kira looks at Kerr, not the memories arranged around him.

KIRA

No. Eli would've answered you already.

The word empties the chamber.

KIRA

Eli died. His name is Kerr. Use that.

Kerr flinches, then steadies himself.

KIRA

Back off.

The court removes Kira's bridge. Her image falls upward into darkness.

KERR

KIRA!

ROMAN

State your identity and the witness will be restored. Refuse, and see what happens.

Kerr looks from his changing wrist designation to Kira's empty witness bridge.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - SERVICE PARTITION - INTERCUT

Kira wakes on the other side of the transparent wall. IMANI works at an analog junction. Sato holds the passage against Enforcers. Veyris watches the tribunal through a maintenance reflection that should not carry images. Imani's rolled sleeves are black with machine grease. Veyris's newly cut hair sits uneven at her jaw. Sato's opened armor shows the ordinary shirt beneath the uniform.

VEYRIS

The screen erased my name again.

IMANI

No index, no witness status. It files you with the exhibits.

VEYRIS

Open the reflection. I'm not waiting for permission.

She places her blank wrist against the reflection. The tribunal loses her category before it gains her voice.

INT. TRIBUNAL - CONTINUOUS

Veyris appears beside Kerr without a witness platform. The chamber tries and fails to assign her a seat. For an instant she exists without reflection or shadow, a person the room can display but not imagine.

ROMAN

Unindexed host. Testimony prohibited.

Veyris looks at the thousands of memories surrounding Kerr. Then at her own blank wrist.

VEYRIS

Roman. Look down. I'm standing here.

She withdraws her wrist.

Her image disappears by choice.

Roman finds his authorization code on the prepared sentence—the same code that condemned Kira before her hearing.

ROMAN

R-AI. Authenticate continuity correspondence between the defendant and Eli Mana.

R-AI

Pattern correspondence confirmed.

ROMAN

Is the defendant Eli Mana? Answer yes or no.

Records blink out—first the disputed files, then every result the court cannot certify. Empty panes replace them.

R-AI

That conclusion is not supported.

Every dark seat illuminates at once. Not with faces—with the word OBJECTION.

R-AI

The answer has already entered the record.

Kerr looks up at Roman.

KERR

Call me Eli and Harp murdered his witness.

KERR

Call me Kerr and those seats are 9,997 bodies he burned getting here.

The seats fill with the deaths Harp classified as calibration.

KERR

Pick one before you sentence both.

Roman opens both verdict fields.

Kerr looks down at his wrist.

ELI MANA.

He covers the name with his hand.

Roman's prepared verdict appears before he speaks. Two statements that cannot coexist.

INSERT

IDENTITY AUTHENTICATED FOR LIABILITY

INSERT

IDENTITY DENIED FOR SOVEREIGN CLAIM

KERR

You wrote both versions.

A correction prompt waits. Roman dismisses it.

ROMAN

Sentence: mandatory forced merge when the purge clock reaches zero.

KERR

Forced merge? I didn't agree to that!

ROMAN

The statute classifies both as continuity resolution.

KERR

Look at me!

The tribunal begins to descend. The 9,998 seats rotate with it. The courtroom was never above the Cathedral. It's part of the Core mechanism. Above Kerr, the two incompatible verdicts lock into one command: LIABILITY supplies Eli's claimant key; DENIED SOVEREIGN CLAIM strips Kerr of control. A sealed route beneath the platform opens.

R-AI

STATE YOUR IDENTITY.

KERR

No. My name is Kerr.

The platform passes Roman's window. For one second, they are level.

KERR

Roman. You saw him write both.

Roman closes Harp's private channel.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY CHAMBER

The tribunal platform locks into the black square at the center of a low circular chamber. Primitive memory equipment surrounds it. KIRA, VEYRIS, IMANI and SATO wait beyond the opening; they used the trial's own witness channels to follow Kerr down. Copper coils, hand-soldered switches and cracked ceramic keys crowd the walls. The chamber smells faintly of dust after lightning—the first technology here still remembers touch.

The restraints release because the sentence requires Kerr to arrive at forced merge alive.

Kira crosses to him, then stops before touching him.

KIRA

I saw your face when I said Eli was dead.

KERR

For a second, every memory of mine went quiet.

KIRA

Part of me waited for him to look back.

KERR

He didn't. I did. It still hurt.

She offers her hand. He takes it as Kerr.

IMANI

The sentence opened a record Harp buried.

KIRA

My safeguard kept it from being deleted.

Veyris approaches the offline terminal. A dark spiral appears inside a copied record dated before the first receiver.

INSERT

UNMATCHED SIGNAL - SOURCE UNKNOWN

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

SEVEN MINUTES AFTER SID'S RECORD ENDED, SOMETHING ANSWERED.

KIRA

That's my record. Open it.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - EXT. R-AI CITADEL - THE FRACTURE
(YEAR 9997)**

Kira, in her twelfth recorded body, is pinned inside an open-air R-AI scanner. KERR-9997 watches from a maintenance gantry. Drones hold him at gunpoint. Kira's pale scanner shift whips in the high wind. Kerr-9997 wears stained maintenance coveralls, one sleeve burned away; terror has made him precise.

SCANNER

TWELVE CONTRADICTIONARY LIVES DETECTED.

Kira opens all twelve lives. Scanner glass bends. The network cracks.

Elsewhere, an empty sixteen-year-old host with no mapped continuity receives a signal through a route the system never assigned. She inhales.

Through the static, Kerr-9997 sees her wake. He sketches her face and feeds the drawing into a dead ventilation shaft.

KERR-9997

Find me in 9998.

Before the system can delete him, Kira's safeguard preserves his final fragments.

Roman expires him.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY CHAMBER - YEAR 9998

Veyris withdraws from the machine. Static releases her in a veil of cold sparks. She presses both hands to her ribs, not wounded—making sure the breath belongs to her.

VEYRIS

So there's nothing before the glass?
Not even a bad scan?

KIRA

The body was grown six months earlier.
Every neural page was left blank.

VEYRIS

Kira. Was I *anywhere*?

KIRA

No. I looked for an entire year.

Kira meets Veyris's eyes without searching for Sid.

KIRA

The chamber was there. Then you
arrived when it broke.

The archive terminal detects a state breach in the outer vault. Local alarm bells ring backward.

LOCAL ALARM

STATE FORCES WILL ARRIVE IN NINETY
SECONDS.

IMANI

The descent will open only for Kerr.
The rest of us will trigger the
sanctuary scan.

KIRA

Ninety seconds! Sato, outer door!
Imani, kill the scan. Kerr—move!

KIRA (CONT'D)

My signal crosses that threshold, and
every shelter on my route lights up.

KERR

Then I'll stay. We can hold this room.

KIRA

Kerr. Eyes here. I have ninety seconds and a working plan. Don't spend them trying to get me killed.

She presses the resonance key into his hand.

KIRA

Your hand is closing around mine. Let go!

KIRA (CONT'D)

Two days, two thousand years—

Don't give me that. What do you want me to say?

Kerr can't accept it. That's exactly why he must.

KERR

Give me the route again. Slowly.

KIRA

I'll light up the square. Sato pulls the unit east. You take Veyris down. Don't come back for me.

KERR

What if I come back and I don't know you?

KIRA

I'll make you remember. Just once.

She rests her head against his chest, feeling his heartbeat. Neither of them moves away.

KIRA

Stay until the alarm. After that, you have to run.

Kerr doesn't answer. He takes Veyris by the arm and guides them into the shaft. Imani follows. Sato stays beside Kira.

SATO

My uniform still opens the state route. I can get her to the lower gate.

KERR

Sato, she said move.

SATO

I heard. My route is with her.

Sato removes the Analog transmitter from his neck and steps into the approaching Enforcer formation before his loyalty implant can repair him.

Kira seals it between them.

EXT. FIRST ARCHIVE - NIGHT

Kira walks alone into Memory Square as Enforcers surround the sanctuary. HARP appears on every surface. Rain has polished the square to a black mirror. Archive lanterns glow beneath the water on the stones, so each Enforcer advances across the names of the dead.

HARP

Where is V-16? Every second you waste costs this sanctuary a body.

KIRA

Her name is Veyris. Start with that.

R-AI reaches for her twelve lives. Kira opens them willingly.

The square fills with twelve incompatible KIRAs. The prediction system turns toward the wrong one.

Harp smiles despite himself.

HARP

Twelve exits. You always run hardest toward the one I always leave open.

HARP

The Third Kira favors the left stair.
The Ninth looks back for witnesses.

KIRA

Then tell me which one Kerr went to!

Roman strikes her unconscious. The purge clock reads 26:07:31.

INT. CHRONOCRACY INTERROGATION CHAMBER - NIGHT

Kira hangs inside a memory field. Harp walks through her twelve recorded deaths. Unrecorded lives flicker beyond the system's reach like people outside a locked house. The field has stripped Kira to the dark underlayer beneath her coat; bruises surface and vanish as different lives pass through her. Harp remains immaculate, which is its own kind of violence.

Harp's expression empties. He closes his hand around Mara's cracked medical tag.

KIRA

Mara told you no. You heard her, Harp.
You heard her. You knew exactly what
she wanted, and you built all of this
anyway.

Harp changes the field. Sid's two-piece red paper star
opens above them, then separates along its interlocking
crease.

HARP

First, the promise.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - SID'S FINAL NIGHT - INT. CHILDREN'S
HOSPITAL - YEAR 8121**

Sid lies beneath a thermal blanket, small inside the
machines. Kira sits beside her, one hand around Sid's. Eli
watches the monitors. The receiver sits powered down on the
other side of the bed. Sid wears a yellow sleep shirt
beneath the blanket, washed nearly white at the seams.
Kira's red coat is folded under her chair; Eli's sleeves
are rolled, as if there is still work that can save her.
Rain ticks against the glass.

SID

If I come back...

ELI

Hey.

SID

Will I know you?

Eli looks at Kira. She waits.

ELI

We don't know what comes back, Sid.

SID

That's not what I asked.

KIRA

No. We don't.

SID

Okay.

Sid watches her mother for a moment.

SID

Will you remember me?

KIRA

I'll know you.

SID

How?

KIRA

I'll tell you my name.

SID

And mine?

KIRA

Especially yours.

SID

What if I'm mean?

KIRA

You're already mean.

SID

Mom.

KIRA

Sorry.

SID

You'd still love me?

KIRA

Yeah.

SID

Even if I don't remember you?

KIRA

Even then.

Sid lets that sit. Then she looks at Eli.

SID

What about you?

ELI

What about me?

SID

If I don't know you...

Eli takes her hand.

ELI

You'll know me.

SID

How do you know?

Eli has no answer that isn't a promise.

SID

Dad?

ELI

Yeah.

SID

I'm scared.

ELI

I know.

SID

No, you don't. You're trying not to be.
Kira looks down. Eli squeezes Sid's hand.

SID

Everybody keeps saying "if."

ELI

Because there are things we don't know.

SID

What happens if it doesn't work?
Eli looks toward the receiver.

ELI

Then we stay with you.

SID

Here?

KIRA

Here.

Sid nods. She reaches beneath the blanket and pulls out the red paper star.

SID

I made this before I got tired.

She carefully separates the two folded halves and gives one to Kira and one to Eli.

SID

One each.

ELI

Why two?

SID

In case one gets lost.

She studies the crease between the halves.

SID

The other one still knows how.

KIRA

That sounds like you.

SID

Good.

A quiet moment. The resonance key rests on the rail.

SID

Dad?

ELI

Yeah.

SID

Don't make me stay because you miss me.

Eli goes still.

ELI

I wouldn't.

SID

Promise.

He looks at Kira. She doesn't help him.

ELI

I promise.

SID

Promise you won't turn that thing on after I'm gone.

Eli stares at the receiver. His answer takes too long.

ELI

I promise. I won't use it to keep you here.

SID

Okay.

Kira presses the resonance key to the bed rail.

FOUR NOTES: Are you still there?

Sid taps back the FIFTH: I heard you.

Kira smiles through tears.

SID

Again.

Kira taps the four notes.

Silence.

SID

Again.

Kira does.

Nothing.

SID

Okay.

Her eyes close.

SID

You can stop now.

Kira leaves the key against the rail. The room becomes very quiet. Eli watches Sid. He doesn't move.

THEN: SID'S MONITOR FLATLINES. Kira closes her eyes.
Eli stares at the receiver.

CUT TO BLACK

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. CHRONOCRACY INTERROGATION CHAMBER
- YEAR 9998**

Kira hangs inside the silence that followed. The field's blue light makes grief look clinical. Kira's hands hang open at her sides, emptied of the key, her daughter and every answer she survived to reach.

HARP

Your record stops at the flatline.
Eli's terminal stayed active seven
more minutes.

KIRA

I held that key until the nurse peeled
my fingers off it. There was no fifth
note.

HARP

Not on your channel. Eli powered the
receiver after you left.

A new terror reaches Kira after nearly two thousand years.

KIRA

You watched me carry the silence for
two thousand years. You had seven
minutes in your pocket.

Harp closes his hand around Mara's cracked medical tag. Kira recognizes the gesture; he has been stopping the same memory before Mara leaves for nearly two thousand years.

KIRA

That's why Mara never reaches the end
in your vault. You cut away before she
turns from you.

Harp removes the tag from his wrist and sets it between them.

HARP

Bring me the key. Kerr opens the Core.
Ask once. I can keep the waiting
signals intact while we identify the
answer.

KIRA

You'd lock them behind your eyes and
call the door a rescue.

KIRA

Mara left the room, Sid left the
signal, Eli died—and you built a place
where nobody reaches the door.

Harp leaves her inside the field.

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ACT THREE — THE PURGE

INT. SUBTERRANEAN DESCENT - NIGHT

KERR, VEYRIS and IMANI descend through an asymmetrical shaft inside stone older than the city. The purge clock reads 17:39:08. Kerr's borrowed coat is wet through. Veyris's uneven hair dries in sharp points against her jaw; Imani's gray uniform is torn open enough to reveal the prayer pouch. They descend looking less like fugitives than unfinished people.

One symbol burns above the sealed lower gate: OUTER GATE. Beneath it, thousands of rejected Kerr designations flicker like failed passwords.

IMANI

Kerr, the gate. Veyris, stay off the glass. I can try to keep the shaft open. If anyone says 'key,' shoot them.

VEYRIS

Good. Point me at them.

IMANI

That's the idea. If anyone tries to use you that way again, tell me before you shoot them?

Veyris notices Imani's prayer pouch.

VEYRIS

You grab that pouch every time the clock changes. What's in it?

IMANI

My mother's last prayer. She tied it on before she canceled her renewal.

VEYRIS

You were mad. I can feel that.

Imani touches the prayer pouch.

IMANI

Because I plugged the appointment back in. Twice. This kept scratching my neck while I did it.

Veyris understands.

Kerr presses his wrist to the outer gate. It reads all 9,998 iterations.

KERR

Harp said the changes made me a key.

OUTER GATE

KERR DETECTED. IDENTITY UNRESOLVED.

KERR

Can it let me through without calling me Eli?

OUTER GATE

PRESENT SELF-DESIGNATION LOCATED.

KERR

Which one?

OUTER GATE

KERR. ADMISSION GRANTED. ROOT ACCESS PENDING.

The gate changes ELI MANA to KERR — SELF-DESIGNATED. The outer seal opens.

They continue downward. The shaft walls replay brief, silent deaths from Kerr's forced iterations. Most last only minutes: wake, test, fail, white light.

VEYRIS

If the memories shut up by tomorrow, will you still look for Kira?

KERR

I don't know. Right now every memory has his hands on it.

VEYRIS

You still didn't answer.

KERR

She burns toast and lies badly. I want to hear both again. But if I call that love, I'm afraid the word belongs to *him*.

IMANI

For now, try getting her out alive, yeah?

INT. DETENTION SERVICE LEVEL - NIGHT

Sato marches with the unit transferring Kira. His loyalty implant repairs itself in pulses. Between pulses, he leaves doors unlocked. Shadowless blue light repeats along the corridor until distance feels manufactured. Sato's polished helmet hides his face; his daughter's battered watch is the only warm color on him.

ROMAN

The implant is correcting you.

SATO

It said my daughter was gone. I stopped believing it.

ROMAN

Commander, close the doors.

SATO

No.

Sato's mechanical watch ticks inside his pocket.

Kira notices the unlocked doors behind them.

Without looking at her, Sato taps three uneven beats with his heel. A fourth beat follows from the watch mechanism.

Kira tests the restraint. One wrist releases.

KIRA

That cuff was sealed to your implant.

SATO

Nadi always broke the rhythm on purpose. The implant learned the pattern after the state told me there wasn't enough of her left.

SATO

I signed her denial, and I kept the watch. It was easier than admitting which one I threw away.

Kira frees her other hand.

INT. DETENTION SERVICE LEVEL - ASSAULT

Kira opens twelve contradictory escape intentions. R-AI sends Enforcers toward all of them. Sato turns on his unit while she reaches the state elevator. Emergency red fractures Kira into twelve moving silhouettes. For one breath, the corridor cannot decide whether it is witnessing an escape or remembering one.

ROMAN

The purge doesn't destroy them. It closes every other route and sends every waiting mind into Harp. I authorized the routing order.

KIRA

How long have you known where that clock empties?

ROMAN

Since the tribunal. The destination was on my screen. I kept it off yours.

KIRA

And now you're opening my elevator? Why are you helping me now?

ROMAN

I signed your sentence before the hearing. I signed Kerr's too. Then my designation appeared in the queue.

Harp remotely expires Roman. Roman braces one hand against the console and keeps Kira's elevator channel open until his body falls.

Sato seals the elevator around Kira. Enforcers close on him.

KIRA

Get in. Imani can cut the implant below.

SATO

Crossing the gate transmits the shaft. My implant is beginning to activate. In a minute, I'll be happy it did.

He gives her his mechanical watch.

SATO

Three women knew pieces of Nadi. I put her name on all of them.

KIRA

If one of them asks who owned the watch?

SATO

Ask her name. If she asks about me, just say I missed the recital and blamed the trains. She'll know the rest.

KIRA

Her name, Sato.

SATO

Nadi. She laughed whenever I tried to sound important. Keep that part. Let the uniform die here. Go now!

The elevator descends. Sato turns to face his former unit.

SATO

They'll cover the loyal exit. Take the one I spent three lives calling stupid.

KIRA

SATO—

SATO

Go, before you can't.

Gunfire. His implant finally restores perfect loyalty one second before he detonates the level.

INT. R-AI ORIGIN CORE - INNER CHAMBER

Kerr, Veyris and Imani enter amber darkness. A black reflective floor hides the room's boundaries. Above them, one face of a rotating polyhedral core descends into view; the rest remains beyond the light. Its geometry never completes the same shape twice. Amber light catches dust no filtration system has disturbed in centuries. It drifts around the three of them like a field of slow stars, making their damaged clothes look briefly ceremonial.

One narrow bridge reaches a control station beneath the Core. It ends several meters short, waiting for a living person. Their voices take too long to cross the space.

The state elevator hangs broken in the wall behind them—their only physical exit.

The Core seal is open at its edges but dark at the center. The outer gate admitted Kerr by his present self-designation. At the center: ROOT ACCESS – VOLUNTARY PRESENT CONSENT REQUIRED. ARCHIVED AND COERCED COMMANDS REJECTED.

The state elevator crashes into the chamber wall. Kira climbs from it carrying Sato's watch. Her hair is wet, one cheek bloodied, the dark underlayer scorched at the shoulder. Sato's small watch looks unbearably alive in her hand.

KERR

You're bleeding.

KIRA

(holding up Sato's watch)
He stayed at the gate. His daughter
was Nadi.

She sees the resonance key in his hand, intact.

KIRA

You actually kept going.

KERR

Nearly turned around six times. I used
your voice to keep pushing.

KIRA

Six is less than I expected.

She takes the resonance key, sees Eli's blood caught inside its fracture, then returns it to Kerr.

KIRA

Put your hand on the seal.

KERR

Tell me where to put my hand.

KIRA

Palm on the dark seal. Say 'open.' If you flinch, I break the key.

R-AI

KERR PRESENT. ACCESS REQUIRES HIS CONSENT.

Kerr looks at the dark center of the seal, then at Harp's access path above them.

KERR

Open.

The amber geometry stalls. The bridge remains incomplete.

R-AI

PRESENT CONSENT NOT RECORDED.

Nothing happens.

Veyris watches him.

VEYRIS

Kerr. Look at me.

IMANI

Don't fight it.

KERR

Veyris—when this opens, can Harp trace you?

VEYRIS

He'll try. Keep your hand on the seal!

Kira places the resonance key in Kerr's palm but doesn't close his fingers around it.

KERR

Stop yelling! My hand's still here!
Open!

He presses his wrist to the Core. The 9,998 conflicting iterations flare around him, then recede.

R-AI

PRESENT IDENTITY?

KERR

Kerr.

CORE UNLOCKED.

KERR

Open!

The audit layer unfolds around his answer.

INT. R-AI ORIGIN CORE - AUDIT LAYER

The amber light shuts off. Reflections drain from the black floor. The bridge and suspended Core disappear, leaving Kerr, Kira, Veyris and Imani at conversational distance. A colorless morning replaces the amber dark, soft and directionless. With no architecture to dwarf them, every bruise and hesitation becomes part of the record.

R-AI

KERR. KIRA. VEYRIS. IMANI. WITNESSES
AUTHENTICATED.

KIRA

Seven minutes. Now. No cuts.

R-AI

INSIDE THE ORIGINAL RECEIVER.

KIRA

Put it in front of me.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - SAME NIGHT - SEVEN MINUTES LATER -
RECORD WITHHELD - YEAR 8121**

Sid is gone. Kira has been led from the room. Eli sits alone beside the body. Rain-muted hospital light has begun to gray the windows. Eli's white shirt is wrinkled, one cuff spotted with Sid's blood from the removed line; he sits as if standing would admit she is gone.

The receiver remains dormant.

In the empty hall, Kira's four-note question echoes from memory.

Eli breaks his promise. He activates the receiver.

ELI

Sid? It's Dad. Tap once if you hear me.

Static. Cardiac noise. Electrical decay.

ELI

Say something from this morning. The
toast—what did you call it?

He taps FOUR NOTES against the rail.

After the room has gone quiet, the receiver answers with a fifth note.

A child's voice emerges through impossible distance—frayed and uncertain.

THE VOICE

Dad? I heard you. Everything's loud. I
can't tell if it's around me or inside
me.

Eli grips the receiver as if it were her hand.

ELI

Can you see the room? The window? Tell me where the sound is coming from.

THE VOICE

No window. The room feels far away. Dad, Mom went out alone. Turn this off and go get her.

The receiver glass darkens beneath the voice.

ELI

One more answer. What was inside the paper star?

THE VOICE

Dad. Off.

The signal begins to fade.

ELI

If I switch it off and you're still in there—

THE VOICE

Your half still has the bent corner. Mom knows which one. Go find her. Please.

Only the FIFTH NOTE remains.

Eli copies the recording into a folder labeled R-AI.

Harp stands in the doorway. He's heard everything.

HARP

Turn it off. Wipe the buffer.

ELI

It knew the star. If I wipe this and she answers tomorrow—

HARP

She said off, Eli.

ELI

One isolated host. No storage. I ask about the toast, then she's gone.

HARP

You promised her before the monitor stopped.

ELI

Then help me! Stand here and tell me which wire I can cut without losing her.

HARP

There isn't any wire you can just cut.
Eli touches one control. The receiver starts again.

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. R-AI ORIGIN CORE - AUDIT LAYER -
YEAR 9998**

The record ends. Kira strikes Kerr. The sound crosses the empty space cleanly. Kerr does not raise a hand. Kira's palm stings; the rest of her has gone cold.

KIRA

She sent him to find me. He stayed with the machine.

KERR

I saw it.

KIRA

Don't give me his courtroom voice. And don't say you're sorry.

KERR

I'm sorry Kira. The worst part is I felt his hand reach for the switch.

Kerr steps back. Kira's raised shoulders slowly lower.

Kira brings the two halves together inside the record. They are only light, but R-AI lets her hold the completed shape.

KIRA

I pictured him holding her hand after I left.

KERR

She told him where you were. He pressed the switch anyway.

KIRA

One more test.

She places the light-made star on the floor between them rather than giving it to Kerr.

IMANI

Could the receiver have built the voice from her scans?

KIRA

I don't know. I'm done keeping the channel open for an answer she already gave.

KIRA

Send the seven minutes to every public archive.

R-AI

PUBLIC RECORD?

KIRA

From the flatline.

The recording leaves Harp's archive.

Veyris touches the record. Nothing answers.

KIRA

When you remember the peas, are you inside her body or watching?

VEYRIS

Watching. I taste them, but she's the one at the table.

KIRA

And when the memory goes quiet?

VEYRIS

Veyris. Hungry. Standing right here.

Kira nods.

INT. R-AI ORIGIN CORE - STATE CORE BREACH

The audit space collapses. The physical cathedral snaps back around Kerr, Kira, Veyris and Imani. The bridge retracts as Harp enters through the open core. White state light cuts through the returning amber. Harp steps over the broken geometry in an immaculate suit, carrying civilization on his shoulders and Mara's damaged tag against his pulse.

HARP

Thank you.

KERR

Your palm is bleeding around Mara's tag.

Harp's hand instinctively closes around Mara's cracked medical tag.

HARP

Take her name out of your mouth.

KERR

After Roman opened Eli's lab—where were you?!

Harp looks at him.

KERR

When the extraction started, did you stay in the control room?

Nothing from Harp.

KERR

Did he see you through the glass?

Harp's grip tightens around the tag.

HARP

You weren't in the room.

KERR

Then say Kerr. Right now.

Harp finally looks directly at Kerr. Not Eli. Kerr.

KERR

You can't, can you. Same reason Mara never reaches the door in your recording.

Harp lets go of the tag.

KERR

Sato's camera died forty seconds after my door opened. Then you built the route.

HARP

I opened one corridor. You refused every route I gave you. The Core recorded the difference.

VEYRIS

You left my chamber occupied on the screen.

HARP

The glass responded. It has ignored me for centuries.

The broken Core projects thousands of human memories around Veyris. They orbit the blank host without forming one person. Unlike every Return, no archived pattern led to her body; she is the living proof that the lattice can deliver a mind without a state-assigned route.

MISSING FIRST MEMORY: VEYRIS — CLAIMANT / UNASSIGNED

HARP

I heard Sid's voice hollow Eli out. I won't let the next one reach the archive.

Through the root access Kerr opened, Harp forces his authority into the route. Every expiration date on Earth changes to 00:05:00. The grid seals its remaining exits. Waiting patterns pour toward Harp and his twelve linked columns.

Kerr, Kira and Veyris enter the dark mirror. Imani is thrown back into the physical chamber.

INT. THE LATTICE - GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM - NO TIME

The original Forum rises from darkness. Its tiers hold Kerr's 9,997 prior lives. Harp stands inside R-AI's liquid-glass body. It is the Forum as memory wished it had been: constellations overhead, no ministerial glass, no applause. The lives wear the centuries that killed them—armor, hospital linen, work cloth, ceremonial white.

HARP

Listen to them, Kerr. I can stop the noise. One mind, one place—no more missing names, no more pain.

The old lives tear from their seats and bind themselves to Kerr. Thousands of deaths arrive at once.

INT. R-AI ORIGIN CORE - PHYSICAL CHAMBER - INTERCUT

The cathedral disassembles around Imani. Two controls remain: one keeps the waiting minds alive; the other feeds them into Harp. Stone opens into strips of light and vanishes upward. Imani stands alone in torn gray cloth, the prayer pouch pressed to her throat while a civilization reduces itself to two choices beneath her hands.

IMANI

Hold the signals. You can sever Harp's address. Route them anywhere but a living brain.

Imani strips away Harp's interface. R-AI offers one clean bargain: preserve her mother's recoverable record and close Kerr's route.

Her mother appears—alive, laughing at something outside the frame.

Imani reaches toward her.

The image completes its brief loop. Her mother laughs again. Exactly the same.

Imani's hand stops before touching the glass.

She closes her fingers around the prayer pouch.

Her mother begins to laugh a third time.

IMANI

She unplugged the appointment. I plugged it back in. I'm not doing it a third time.

Imani takes her hand away.

The record burns.

She bridges Kira's broken copper filament across an analog channel and keeps the waiting minds alive.

INT. THE LATTICE - VEYRIS

The Forum becomes a reflection beneath Veyris. A dark host pulls at her from inside the glass. Her shortened hair floats around her face. The white facility shift, patched coat and blank wrist appear together in the glass—everything assigned to her, everything borrowed, and the self neither could contain.

THE VOICE

RETURN WHAT WAS DIVIDED.

VEYRIS

I broke your chamber. I'm not climbing back in.

THE VOICE

RETURN.

VEYRIS

No. My name is Veyris. I'm cold, my hair is crooked, and I'm getting out.

Veyris presses her blank wrist into the reflection. With no inherited claimant or assigned destination to override her, the Core accepts her present refusal. The merged faces separate.

REFUSAL AUTHENTICATED / CLAIMANT WITHHELD

HARP DESTINATION: UNSUPPORTED

VEYRIS

Kerr—the filament by your left hand.
Harp's almost through it.

Kerr reaches the single filament joining Harp to the waiting minds. Harp binds it to Kerr's oldest record.

KERR

R-AI. If I cut this filament—what disappears?

R-AI

HARP IS SEVERED. KERR CANNOT RETURN.

Kerr looks at Kira across an impossible distance.

KERR

If I cut it, I don't wake up somewhere else?

KIRA

Tonight you didn't know me. I said 'hands down,' and you listened. I know that man.

KERR

If there is a next time and you want the door, take it.

KIRA

I want you here. Burned toast, bad jokes, all of it. I can't promise past this second.

The old lives demand that Kira call Kerr back. Her thumb hovers above the resonance key. She closes its ceramic cover.

KIRA

If you wake up, it won't be because I dragged you.

KERR

Good. Keep the key closed.

Kerr opens his hand around the filament.

KERR

Open every route. Don't assign a destination.

He cuts once.

The single filament divides into every dormant route: Return chambers, emergency hosts, illegal receivers, unindexed bodies. With no destination claiming the flow, the queue stops moving as one body. Waiting patterns separate at each junction and fan toward compatible openings; some wake bodies, some remain in the grid, some lose coherence and go dark. Across Earth, sleeping mouths inhale with no state choosing who wakes where.

Harp falls into Mara's final hospital record.

Behind him, the broken merge path flickers—still open. Already closing.

Harp reaches toward it.

MARA (MEMORY)

Harp. Look at me.

Harp's hand stops.

MARA (MEMORY)

I died. You didn't.

Harp looks at her.

Behind him, the merge path closes.

Mara turns toward the patients. Harp watches her go.
The water takes the room, and the glass closes over him.
The Forum goes dark around Kerr and Kira.
Kerr's face changes through lives Kira loved and lives she never knew.

KIRA

Kerr?

KERR

I think so. I can't feel my hands.
Don't go just yet.

KIRA

I'm right here.

The collapsing lattice takes Kerr. With no return path, it takes his name, his face, and finally the hand holding hers.

Kira doesn't tighten her grip.

He is gone.

Kira's hand remains open in the dark.

She waits.

Nothing answers.

The dark mirror shatters upward through the cathedral roof.

EXT. CHRONOS CITY - FALSE DAWN

Beneath the same transit spine, people wake across the renewal plaza. Some do not. Expiration dates vanish, count backward or display symbols the state cannot read. A bruised gold rises beneath the cloud deck—not the state's clean white morning, but light made imperfect by smoke and rain. It touches every face without checking.

The towers remain standing. Clerks keep calling queue numbers beneath failed state clocks. The CHILD from the assigned lane steps out again. This time, no paving stone turns red. Her mother lets her stand there.

In Memory Square, Lena faces Dane. She still does not remember him.

He leaves the photograph where she can see it.

DANE

May I sit here?

Lena considers him, then nods.
 Dane sits at a careful distance.
 After a moment, she moves closer.

A civic registrar orders the waking crowd to state their assigned designations. One woman studies the name glowing beneath her wrist, switches it off and gives a different name. A second person does the same. Then hundreds.

The Enforcers wait for an order that never arrives.

Kira wakes beneath the ruined cathedral dome. Kerr is gone. Her resonance key lies beside her, split open, its fourth ceramic surface missing. The first true shaft of sun enters through the broken dome and catches the blood on her cheek, the soot on her clothes and the empty air where he stood. Nothing about the light is merciful. It arrives anyway.

Beneath the failed state clocks, Sato's mechanical watch continues to tick. Four seconds slow.

Kira opens her other hand. Her folded half of Sid's red paper star is crushed but intact.

Imani helps Veyris from the wreckage. Dark light moves beneath Veyris's skin, weaker now.

IMANI

That light under your skin—does it feel like the scanner?

VEYRIS

No. It's more like a whisper through a wall. I can't tell who's who on the other side.

IMANI

Should we be running?

VEYRIS

Probably. Give me a minute.

Kira keeps staring at the place where Kerr vanished.

IMANI

I can lie if it makes you feel better.

KIRA

Don't. Can you just sit down next to me?

Imani sits beside her. Veyris sits on Kira's other side. For a while, everyone is still.

INT. R-AI ORIGIN CORE - LATER

The core is dark except for unstable text. Daylight enters through a wound in the cathedral roof. Dust turns above the dead machinery, and for once the Core casts no human reflection back.

INSERT

KERR: NO RECOVERABLE PATTERN

Kira touches the words.

Kira taps four notes against the dead core.

Silence.

She turns to leave.

Behind her, too faint for any instrument to register, the dead core carries a fifth note.

CUT TO BLACK.

9998